



CANDIDATE

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TEST

Knowledge and Reality - TT25 Collections

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Answering Questions

- you must answer THREE questions.
- There are three textboxes in which to type your answer
- When typing each answer, indicate which question you are answering, including whether it is part (a) or (b) for an EITHER... OR... questions.
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1 Question 1

Please type your answer below.

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Q1 "If you had been in the JCR you would have known you have hands, but since you are currently in an epistemology exam you know no such thing." Discuss.

Introduction

This question seeks to establish that the  textualist response to the sceptic is true. Roughly, the sceptic argument (SA) runs as follows:

P1: You do not know that not-H

P2: If you do not know that not-H, then you do not know that O

C: You do not know that  O

where O is some ordinary proposition i.e. you having hands, and H is some sceptical hypothesis you might meet in your epistemology exam i.e. you being a brain-in-a-vat.

Epistemic contextualism (EC) is the semantic thesis that the semantic value of knowledge ascriptions i.e. "S knows that p" depends on a conversational context (in this case, your self-assertion that you know). In essence, there are contexts (such as an epistemology exam) in which the operative standard for knowledge is higher, and other contexts (such as the JCR) in which the operative standard for knowledge is lower. Therefore, whether you know that you have hands depends on the context in which you are situated in.

I think that whether we should accept EC depends on two factors, for any theory T.

(i) Scepticism criterion: A theory T successfully defuses the sceptical hypothesis by answering the question: Do we know that O

(ii) Evidential constraint: A theory T must also explain a wide variety of linguistic phenomenon, or at least, be able to reconcile any putative linguistic/epistemic counterexamples to it.

I argue the following: I know that I have hands regardless of whether I am in the JCR or in the epistemology exam; if my knowledge happens to change, then it is due to some other factor other than the conversational context changing. In particular, I advocate that what changes the operative standard for knowledge are practical features of one's environment, that do not seem to change between in a JCR vs an epistemology exam. I argue this in three steps: (a) I explicate Lewis's variant of EC, and say that it does help us understand why the sceptic is successful sometimes and not in others -- however, I deny that explaining why the sceptic is successful is that significant of a merit as DeRose claims; (b) I advance the argument that EC achieves (i) only to a limited extent by advancing Sosa's objection that EC is orthogonal to scepticism, and that EC completely fails (ii) by ing us to deny rather intuitive epistemic practices; (c) lastly, I advance a counter-theory of  IRI and suggests that it succeeds at least as well as EC for (i) and definitely beats EC with respect to (ii). Therefore, I accept the IRI-ist's conclusion of the above quotation.

Epistemic Contextualism and explaining why the sceptic succeeds

Let us first concretise how the epistemic contextualist succeeds in defusing the sceptical argument (SA). What the epistemic contextualist needs to do is to establish a set of rules in which a conversational context changes the operative standard of knowledge. The easiest version of the theory to see this is through Lewis. Lewis's theory of knowledge is motivated by the fact that we want knowledge to be infallible, but this is extremely difficult except to make justification = truth. But he argues that instead of going for a traditional Justified, True Belief analysis of knowledge, one might simply begin from the justificatory criteria. As a consequence, he makes no reference to truth or belief (though his theory of knowledge entails both). For Lewis, S knows that p just when S's evidence eliminates every possibility that not-p,

except those that are properly ignored. Clearly, the workhorse for Lewis is the last phrase "except those that are properly ignored" -- whether a possibility is properly ignored depends on the conversational context. Lewis presents a series of 7 different rules which determines what kinds of possibilities are properly ignored. The most crucial and relevant to SA is the rule of attention: possibilities that are properly ignored are those that are ignored, and not what could have been ignored. The upshot of this is that as long a possibility of not-p is raised, then not-p must be paid attention to; if not-p possibility is not eliminated by S's evidence, then S does not know that p.

Bringing this back to the example we want to focus on: clearly, the antecedent holds because in the JCR, no one is going to mention the possibility that you do not have hands. So, you are properly ignoring many of the possibilities that you do not have hands -- and for the possibilities in which you do not have hands, for instance, in some world in which you got into a car crash and lost your hands, you would be completely aware of this and your evidence eliminates it. The consequent also holds -- suppose in my Prelims examination, they mentioned that I have been recently envatted -- this is a proposition that entails not-(I have hands) and I have no evidence to eliminate it because I would believe that I have hands and destroy the credibility of my evidence. So, EC helps us understand why in most ordinary contexts, such as the supermarket, we can often utter truths when we say "I know that I have hands".

But DeRose suggests that for (i) the criterion of defusing SA to actually hold, we must explain why we fall into the trap of believing the sceptic anyway. And EC does well in this: by raising our attention to these possibilities, he destroys our knowledge because we can no longer ignore those possibilities uttered. While I accept that EC does well in this, I argue that DeRose is overplaying the importance of this: surely, we can plausibly say that the sceptical argument is either true or false -- a theory is still equally acceptable if it accuses us of simply erring (in some way) for accepting the sceptical argument even though it seems like a perfectly valid and sound argument. So, on this count, I don't think that EC's merit in explaining the SA's occasional success actually matters much.

The many problems with EC

It seems that EC has at least succeeded in (i) -- even if I deny DeRose's additional merit, on my own account, it just doesn't matter whether EC has explained away the SA's occasional successes or not. But I am going to further argue that EC seems somewhat orthogonal to our actual epistemic concerns of whether anyone knows if they have hands or not. Following Sosa, we can set out two arguments. The first is an argument from analogy: EC is a linguistic context and tells when utterances are true -- but that doesn't mean that certain disquotational statements are true such as whether anyone knows that O. For example, just because people utter truths when they say "Someone loves me" does not really bear on the question Does anyone love me? The second argument is an argument from lack of concreteness: Sosa argues that as epistemologist, what we are concerned about are the truth-conditions for the statement "S knows that p" -- he accuses contextualists like Lewis to not have concrete but vague criteria such as "S's evidence eliminating every possibility that not-p except those properly ignored".

I think the second argument is easy to defuse because Sosa's accusation is misplaced: the various rules of attention, belief etc are in fact concrete conditions for the sentence "S knows that p" to obtain. But the first argument is not so: notice that in the question, the question is not asking whether, is your ascription "I know that I have hands" in the JCR a true utterance, but simply whether you know you have hands in the JCR. It is difficult to see how one might defuse this -- DeRose merely asserts that these rules like his Rule of Sensitivity are presented as a conversational rule for convenience and ease of understanding, but never suggests how they can be generalised. Perhaps DeRose's claim is true, but it shows that an additional premise needs to find itself in EC.

Now, I think that EC completely fails the evidential constraint (ii) for two reasons. First, EC violates many normal linguistic practices that we have.

Case 1: Disagreement

Liam: "I know that there is a zebra"

Conversation pauses for 10min

Angie: "How do you know that there is a zebra? You haven't checked that it is not a painted mule!"

Liam: "Oh, you're right...I was wrong -- I didn't know that there was a zebra".

By the contextualist lights, in the first segment of the conversation $c(t_1)$, Liam's assertion was in fact true. This fails to make sense of what happens in $c(t_2)$, particularly the past tense "I was wrong" as a disagreement marker -- Liam was in fact uttering something true in the past! So, clearly, EC fails to make sense of Disagreement

Case 2: Norm of assertion

I think we can accept the following principle, according to Williamson, which is the norm of assertion: "S knows p iff S is in a good enough epistemic position to assert that p ". Now consider the following case -- Hannah and Sarah have the same amount of evidence that the bank is open on Saturday. Hannah has anxiety problems and worries about whether the bank is open on Saturday, not least because she has a mortgage due. Sarah does not have such problems. By the contextualist lights, Hannah does not know that the Bank is open on Saturday, while Sarah does know. But then the following true utterances must be made by Sarah, since the operative context is her own: "Hannah does know that the Bank is open on Saturday, but she is not in a good enough epistemic position to assert that the bank is open on Saturday".

I think that, particularly, in Case 2, the diagnosis of the problem is clear: the first part of her utterance that Hannah does know that the bank is open on Saturday is true because we are evaluating the epistemology standard as Sarah's but the second part of her utterance that Hannah is not in a good enough position to assert the same claim is because we take the epistemic position to be evaluated against Hannah's (the subject of the knowledge claim) epistemic position. What this shows is that we have reason to change, if any, the epistemic standard based on the subject's rather than some conversational context, independent of the subject.

Even then, EC fails to provide a unique explanation for cases in which it can explain -- in particular, cases where unrealised possibilities of error are raised. Take the case of disagreement -- EC takes the fact that our epistemic standards are raised after what Angie says as evidence that our knowledge ascriptions do become more stringent due to possibilities being raised. But Williamson offers an alternative account: he suggests that we are in fact wrong to make our epistemic standard more stringent, like in the epistemology exam, because we are faced with psychological bias in the form of the saliency heuristic -- we overweight possibilities that are salient as more likely than they actually are. These are equally good explanations I think, and it shows that EC lacks unique evidential value.

Interest-Relative Invariantism as an alternative

Given that EC has failed (ii), we must evaluate how good of an alternative Stanley's IRI is. Stanley argues that there is only one operative epistemic standard that matters, which is dependent on the practical features of the environment, and how it affects the subject's stakes. Practical features affect a subject's stakes just when it changes the preference ordering of actions available to her. For example, consider the case of Hannah and Sarah. Hannah has high stakes, because she has a mortgage due; while Sarah has low stakes, because she has no mortgage due. IRI predicts that the claim Hannah does not know that the bank is open on Saturday and Sarah knows that the bank is open on Saturday is true, and this corresponds to our intuitions about what the case is. Furthermore, because whether I am a BIV doesn't really change my preference ordering of my actions (at least normally), I can ignore the sceptical hypothesis as practically relevant. So IRI fulfils (i) just as well as EC. The upshot of IRI is that

we know that we have hands both in the JCR and the epistemology exam, since no practical feature relevant to the stakes of my having hands changes across the epistemology exam and the JCR.

I think that IRI is preferable over EC for two reasons related to (ii). First, it is not actually about knowledge ascriptions and so not a "semantic thesis but a metaphysical thesis about knowledge relations" -- so it is more resistant to Sosa's objection. Second, it can handle cases of disagreement and norms of assertions, because IRI anchors the operative standard to the subject of knowledge -- and this is the crucial point. There is no divergence between the ascriber and the subject of knowledge anymore. One might object that IRI fails to handle the following case: High-ascriber and Low subject stakes. According to the objection, Hannah says something true when she says "Sarah knows that the bank is open on Saturday". According to this objection, this is counterintuitive because Hannah herself does not know that the bank is open on Saturday, and this knowledge entails truth of the proposition, she should competently deduce this fact herself and come to know that the bank is open on Saturday. Stanley offers a really weak response that we can't trust our intuitions here, but I think that there is a stronger reply available. The objection assumes that when Hannah says something true, she also knows that "Sarah knows that the bank is open on Saturday." And so, single premise closure entails the paradoxical conclusion. But Hannah clearly does not know that Sarah knows that the bank is open on Saturday -- she will likely say something false i.e. "Sarah does not know that the bank is open on Saturday", but that is completely fine. What is problematic is if she knows that Sarah knows, but clearly, this is false. The disjunct between ascriber and subject is something that we need to maintain.

Conclusion

I have denied the above material conditional: we know that we have hands regardless of whether we are in the JCR or the epistemology exam. This is because IRI is a more compelling thesis and fulfils (i) at least as well EC while doing much better on the evidential constraint (ii). Unfortunately, while EC fulfils (i) quite well, it fails completely to make sense of our widely held linguistic practices that we would rather not give up if there is a better alternative to solve the sceptical argument problem.

Words: 2487

If your answer isn't tailored to this specific question; if it could be used for a range of essay questions, then reread the question carefully and check you aren't just giving the examiner a preprepared essay. This seemed to miss what is unique about this question completely. It is a perfectly nice essay in answer to many questions but not really aimed at this specific one. 66

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Answered.

2 Question 2

Please type your answer below.

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Q9 Is affording agents too much credibility ever a form of epistemic injustice?

Introduction

Fricker argues that there is a distinctively epistemic way in which injustice can be done to someone qua knower, namely through (i) testimonial injustice: that due to identity-prejudices, we give a deflated level of credibility to a speaker than we would otherwise have given, (ii) hermeneutical injustice: that due to hermeneutical marginalisation or lack of access to these resources of interpretation, individuals are not able to convey their experiences to others as speakers.

The focus on this essay is clearly that of (i) because credibility is only ever relevant to testimonial injustice. According to Fricker, credibility excess does not constitute a form of epistemic injustice, or at least does not comprise a central case of testimonial injustice. Her arguments for this seem to centre around the fact that credibility excess does not lead to the same kind of harm as credibility deficits, and often times cannot be due to a deep-seated identity-prejudice. I am going to agree with Fricker that affording agents too much credibility is never a form of epistemic injustice, but I differ in my explanation for this. I proceed in three steps. First, I suggest that the her discrimination of credibility excess cases from deficit cases does rests on very hand wavy descriptions of what is different between the harm dealt to someone being given excess vs deflated credibility. I contend that the reason for this flaw is continuous with the main flaw of her overall account -- she neglects that harm is not ipso facto a reason for injustice to occur, and never concretises a set of rights that speakers have. I suggest that once we do this, we can make her exclusion of credibility excess cases far more compelling. Second, I present a novel argument, inspired by Coady's suggestion that epistemic injustice is fundamentally distributive, that credibility excess can be a form of injustice when it is causally related with people having credibility deficits. This is a powerful argument that Fricker's account on her own cannot handle. Third, and this is where I depart from Fricker, I defend the thesis against the distributional argument by suggesting that epistemic injustice is not distributional, and that epistemic injustice does not rest on credibility differences per se, but on the failure of reciprocity in linguistic exchanges. Credibility differences are merely incidental and symbolic of this failure of reciprocity.

Fricker's Central Case of Testimonial Injustice

Let us examine Fricker's reason for focusing on credibility deficits in testimonial injustice as her "central case of testimonial injustice". She often reflects upon the case in Harper Lee's *How to Kill a Mockingbird*, where Tom Robinson, a black man, is accused of a crime, and white jurors deflated his credibility in virtue of him being a black man. There are two parts to testimonial injustice, according to Fricker. First, the reason for the credibility deflation is one of negative identity-prejudice. This deep-seated identity-prejudice is one that is a (i) prejudgement and (ii) resistant to counter-evidence. In other words, in some other possible world in which the jurors were mentally identical to those in the actual world but presented with new evidence that Tom Robinson was a gracious man, and against whatever prejudices they have, they would not be fair-minded enough to change their mind. Second, the harm dealt to Tom Robinson is one that is qua knower: according to Fricker, epistemic injustice is deeply connected with a Kantian conception of freedom, that Robinson is not prevented from putting his knowledge out into the world and thus deprived of this freedom essential to rational creatures such as each of us.

How does Fricker then discriminate this very obvious case of epistemic injustice from cases of credibility excess? She gives us the case of a GP who has been given undue credibility by his patients, that he has expertise in all areas of specialisms, even though he does not in fact have such specialisms. He cannot tell his patients that he does not have such credibility, because if not the village will go into chaos (he is the only doctor in the village). According to Fricker, we can see a loser contention that this is as a result of identity-prejudice, since it may very well be the case that once the villagers came across evidence that he is not such a good doctor, they would change their mind. Furthermore, and this is the crucial point, the kind of harm dealt to the doctor, that he is now extremely burdened by this heavy responsibility thrust upon him, is not one that is of the same kind as the harm dealt to Tom Robinson. Now, it is clear that the basis of identity-prejudice as the difference is weak: we can imagine a case in which the villagers are in fact resistant to counter-evidence. But surely, this would not change our intuitive judgement that this is not a case of epistemic injustice. Furthermore, we can also stretch the case such that the GP now feels that he is unable to put out knowledge into the world because of this extra burden that he faces. It is difficult to see how Fricker can distinguish between the two cases in a principled manner.

I think that the key here is, in expanding on Fricker, outlining the set of rights that we have as knowers/speakers. Once this has been done, we can see that the GP case does not violate any epistemic rights that we have, while the Robinson one violates our epistemic rights in a deep way. I think that we can tease out the set of rights that we have once we focus on the kind of harm that Fricker is talking about -- the prevention of putting out knowledge into the world and deprived of a Kantian freedom essential to rational creatures. Here, I see that Fricker's theory of epistemic injustice is clearly underwritten by Anderson's theory of relational justice -- justice is fundamentally one of respect and injustice is to demean an individual in a deep way. In particular, prejudiced exclusion from the discursive exchange of reasons and knowledge is indicative of such disrespect and a harm to the dignity and rights of individuals. Notice here that there is an intentional quality to this form of injustice -- because each individuals, qua knower, is owed some sort of respect from others so as to not be prejudicially excluded, any action to the contrary violates this. Now an explanation to distinguish the cases in a principled manner reveals itself: in the case of the GP, there is no such action which violates the dignity of the doctor, while in the case of Tom Robinson, there is almost a quality of epistemic degradation and objectification, and he is no longer ascribed the respect that he has a right to as a knower and thereby excluded from the arena of reasons that he has a right to participate in. And because most harms of credibility excesses are similar in kind to the GP case, we would not consider it as epistemic injustice. This is, I think, a better explication of Fricker's own position that credibility excesses, at least the case she gives us, is not one of epistemic injustice

Thought this part was good but maybe means you should go back and revise ideas in previous para to match?

The distributive case against credibility excess as injustice

Let us motivate the argument that credibility excess is injustice just when it is causally related to credibility deficits due to identity-prejudices in the following way: Consider that in the current economy, there is a huge wage gap, where individuals like Michael Bloomberg and Elon Musk have accumulated billions of dollars in wealth, while there are homeless individuals on the streets of New York and Los Angeles. Now, we can sure assert that homelessness or the fact of homelessness is an injustice (or rather, let us accept this). When does the fact that Elon Musk having 230+ billion dollars in wealth become an injustice? When the reason for his accumulation is some systematic deprivation of the incomes of others. Notice that I am not saying that for his wealth to be an injustice he himself has to cause the deprivation of others; it just has to be causally related to some degree, perhaps via the institutions and systems that perpetuate it. In short, the reason for there being an injustice when there are (excessive) income differences is because justice in the economy is a matter of distribution.

Let us now take ourselves back to the courtroom: there is a notion of comparative relations between credibility amounts. Tom Robinson is not just evaluated as "uncredible" in silo; he is evaluated as uncredible relative to the so-and-so evidence presented to the jurors. For this argument to hold, we must broadly speaking, argue that epistemic injustice follows a

distributive structure -- namely, that there is a causal relation between credibility excesses and credibility deficits in the "credibility economy". So, one might take it to be an injustice that we give the white testifier excessive credibility, relative to Tom Robinson, because of an identity prejudice to Tom Robinson.

How might Fricker respond to this? To my mind, she would simply deny that epistemic injustice is distributive in any way. She has two arguments for this:

- 1) The argument from obviousness: distribution is not at the heart of epistemic injustice because it "wears its (desired) distribution on its sleeve" and thus is very obvious what the distribution ought to be
- 2) The argument from finiteness: distribution is about goods that are in short supply i.e. like money, while credibility is not in short supply.

Coady denies both (1) and (2) and I think he is right to do so. He correctly questions Fricker's assertion that the fact that we know people's credibility is just what they deserve closes the distributive debate because what people deserve is actually where most of the distributive debate happens. In fact, we can construe Fricker's problem case of the shy testifier as precisely that -- if she wants to say that giving him a deflated credibility is not constitutive of epistemic injustice, then we can plausibly explain this in terms of him not deserving such credibility. Second, Coady similarly suggests that there is a causal relation between credibility amounts, as I have presented in the courtroom case. But I bring this further by questioning the premise that distribution is about goods that are in short supply. While many people (including Rawls himself) focuses on the primary good of money (in his theory of distributive justice), he mentions that the most important primary good that matters is actually the social esteem they have. If credibility is not finite, then so is social esteem. But if social esteem is not finite, then Rawls' theory is not distributive. But Rawls's theory is the paradigmatic case of distributive justice. So, the argument from finiteness is not decisive either. The argument from distribution for credibility excess as injustice stands.

Defusing the distributive argument

Now, how might we defuse the distributive argument without relying on any of Fricker's faulty arguments? I see two ways. First, as I have mentioned earlier, the theory of justice that underwrites epistemic injustice for Fricker is one of Anderson's justice of respect -- it is about the prejudiced exclusion of individuals from the arena of exchanging reasons and knowledge that uniquely attacks one's dignity as a knower. Then, what matters for justice is a minimal amount of respect such that the individual is now well-placed to participate as a knower in the exchange of reasons and knowledge is given to that knower. But one might object that respect is constrained by credibility. And I agree and this is a difficult concern to allay.

I think that we can resolve this through the second, interrelated response, that because we now focus on justice based on respect, we realise that what matters is actually the reciprocity between individuals. Following Dotson, she identifies epistemic violence (which is largely similar to epistemic injustice) as the failure of reciprocity between speaker and hearer -- that the hearer fails to meet the speaker halfway. Credibility differences are just one way that there is such a failure of reciprocity, and mostly incidental to epistemic injustice. We can see this even more clearly in two cases.

The first case consists of Maitra's observation that whether there is an epistemic injustice or not actually depends on the relationship between the two individuals -- for example, we might think that a reader who has a prejudice against some writer may not owe the writer anything to reader his content, but when we think of the Tom Robinson case, what matters is less the credibility deficit itself, but rather the fact that the juror has an obligation as a juror to listen to Robinson objectively and carefully. So, it is the enhanced burden of reciprocity in the second case that is the reason for distinguishing the two.

Secondly, we can also see that the failure of reciprocity is more important in the case of injustice without credibility differences, where a group called Gs take what non-Gs to have said as true, but believe them to be systematically Gettiered such that they are not ascribed the status of knowledge.

Once we see that credibility is only incidentally related to epistemic injustice, and combined with the fact that the notion of justice underwriting Fricker's theory is actually one of respect and reciprocity, the distributional concern falls out of sight -- for it is no longer credibility per se that produces the injustice. What actually finds itself in the reason for testimonial injustice is neither credibility excess or credibility deficit, but rather the societal structure responsible for both phenomena, because the societal structure is one that fails to engender reciprocity. This is, I think, congenial with many traditional theories of injustice that take the subject of justice not to be individuals, but to be the structure of society itself.

Conclusion

In conclusion, I have mounted a new argument from distribution against Fricker -- that epistemic injustice is does not have cases of credibility excesses. This is because the theory of justice that underwrites epistemic injustice is not distributional, but one of reciprocity and respect.

Sophisticated and interesting argument. Strong reasoning. Good knowledge of topic
78

Words: 2403



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Answered.

3 Question 3

Please type your answer below.

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Q20 'If there weren't any racism, there wouldn't be any races.' Discuss.

Introduction

First, let us understand the two senses in which racism exists. There is individual racism, in which a single person makes a racist remark against person(s) and there is systemic racism, in which a group is systematically marginalised due to identifiable features of who they are. In this essay, I want to focus on systemic racism for two reasons: first, we might say that individual racism is a particular feature of systemic racism, especially when individual racism is prevalent across society; second, if we deny the first, then systemic racism is dependent on societal structures while individual racism may not be, and so is more related to the social constructionist view of race.

The proposition "If there weren't any racism, there wouldn't be any races" entails that race is a social construction, dependent on the existence of a hierarchy of races. I am going to deny this particular social constructionist view, that races depend on the structures of subordination and privilege for the core reason that I deny that racism and privilege structures are what makes races real for all races. It may hold true for a particular geographical/national/racial context, but it is only ever locally true and never globally true. In other words, the claim that races existing is dependent on racism is only true for some races, in some countries.

A satisfactory theory of race must achieve the following:

1. Criterion: It must present a workable, unifying membership criterion for some particular race, or deny that this is so
2. Phenomenological explanation: it must also explain experiences that come together with race e.g. discrimination etc

I argue for my position in three steps: first, I suggest that there are conceptual and normative problems with this particular social constructionist view -- that they render "heroic growth" impossible, and it is just not true that all races share this criterion; second, I explore biological realism as an alternative theory, and argue that it remains an open question whether this can be established; lastly, I instead consider a more compelling intersubjectivist theory following Mills, but argue that the intersubjective criterion is local to the races, and we cannot hope to find a intersubjective criterion that is shared amongst all races. I go further by arguing that we should distinguish between a thick and thin conception of race, where a thin conception of race is ethnicity, because that allows us to better explain phenomena of "race traitors" and questions of "who are you really?"

Haslanger's social constructivism

Haslanger is the main proponent of the given analyses -- where the existence of races as we know them today are contingent on the structures of privilege and subordination which are embedded in our society. Her reason for this is because she attempts to give a critical understanding of race by reconciling both normative questions about gender and race, as well as conceptual questions. She argues that traditional analyses of race attempt to find a correspondence between the members of some race and some other biological feature, whereas her analyses of race begins from the normative question of the experiences shared by members of each race to find a unifying criteria. In essence, she suggests that: A group G is racialised just when they are subordinate or privileged in some way relative to other groups, and they are marked by identifiable features taken to represent that they are part of

some group G, and that this fact plays a part in whether they are subordinate or privileged in some way relative to other groups.

The upshot of this are two claims: (i) race is a social kind, as it is dependent and defined against social structures of racism, and (ii) race is real and objective, at least because it is dependent on mind-independent facts such as the societal structures.

I think that there are two problems with Haslanger's analysis. The first reason is a normative problem. Haslanger is committed to a very unintuitive theory of persistence for races. According to her, once the structures of racism are dismantled, these races as we know them now cease to exist. Instead, we have to create new genders and new races that are defined against something else. But I think this view is quite absurd, from the standpoint of anyone. Consider the fact that, now, intrinsic to womanhood and feminism is the story of how girls and women rise to the challenge of the patriarchy -- and if a new gender is created once the structures of subordination are dismantled, I don't imagine that women would want to lose this heroic history that they had. One might say that women in the future would say that their past gender was such-and-such, and had such-and-such experiences, and Haslanger can be committed to them having this heroic history, but I think we can parallel John Perry's criticism against Sider's stage theory against Haslanger: just when I say that "that boy will grow up to be the general" and I mean that boy will actually become the general, part of what matters is that we can say that "that gender/race will one day no longer be suppressed" and we actually mean that gender, not some new gender I-related to the old gender. I liked that point - seems original

But a deeper problem is the following conceptual problem: it is quite clear that not all races as we know them today can be defined against prejudice or oppression -- take perhaps Chinese people for instance. While it is true that they might face some sort of racism, we are hardpressed to say that it is systemic racism to the degree that say, Black people, face and we might also be hardpressed to say that Chinese people define themselves against this particular set of experiences! Furthermore, one faces conceptual difficulty when we want to say that races exists cross nations i.e. Chinese people in America where they might be said to face racism and Chinese people in Singapore and China, where they form the dominant race. Haslanger might handle this by saying that these races differ i.e. a Chinese American is that's an interesting idea different in race from a Chinese Singaporean, but this is highly counterintuitive. I take these two problems to be evidence that we need to reject the claim that "if there were not any racism, there would not be races".

Alternative Theories: Biological Realism

Now, let us briefly consider a challenge from Biological realism: that races cannot depend on racism because it is dependent on something biologically real in races. Its historical association with racism aside, I think that we often dismiss this theory too quickly. Firstly, it depends on who you ask whether there is anything biologically real amongst members of the same race. Spencer may argue that because of genetic clustering analysis corresponding to the racial categories in the US census, there is in fact something biologically real, while Appiah and Shelby might reject this analysis. I think that this contention is made even more difficult to handle once we realise that the bar to find a criteria is not so high. This is motivated from Quine's analysis of natural kinds. For Quine, he argues that natural kinds cannot be defined in terms of projectible predicates, since "not-raven" is not projectible but is a natural kind (more generally, any complement of a projectible predicate is not projectible but a natural kind). It also cannot be defined set theoretically in terms of a consistent membership criteria -- rather, natural kinds, if race were to be something of this sort, is dependent on some vague but irreducible notion of similarity. This, I suggest, makes it far more plausible that race can be a natural kind.

I think the largest problem facing race as a natural kind is, even if this is true, it may just not be what is taken as important by the group. As Mills points out, ancestry is seen as emblematic of what race you're part of, not because ancestry is actually important, but because it is taken

to be important. For instance, if someone subconsciously passed as white and is completely unaware of his black ancestry and grew up in white culture, we would be hardpressed to call that person black. The tenor of his argument is that ancestry is only contingently important. So, biological realism cannot make sense of the metaphysical import of race (and thus fails the phenomenology criteria).

Mills' intersubjectivism and thick/thin conceptions of race

Now, I think it is undeniable that for some races, the experiences of racism are definitive for them. Especially in the context of Haslanger's American centric investigation of race, the black/white dichotomy makes her analysis fit well within her context. But it is also undeniable that for some races, racism is just not important or definitive for them, even from an objective standpoint. This lends itself to Shelby's and Appiah's rejection of there being any social criterion of race, because no single kind of social criterion is shared amongst different races -- for instance, shared values and cultures may not be of importance to white people or black people but are clearly important and perhaps definitive for Chinese.

This motivates my suggestion of Mills' intersubjectivism as the plausible account for race. Mills argues that race is fundamentally a matter of what is taken to be important -- as pointed out earlier, ancestry is only contingently important even though it is a biological factor, because it is taken to be important by institutions, members of one's race and members of other races. But there are cases in which this factor can be defeated -- what comes to mind is the case of Maria Hertough in Singapore, who has European heritage but was given up to a Malay family. When her Dutch parents came back to claim her, there was a huge resistance precisely because (i) the community identified her as Malay given that she grew up in a Muslim household and shared many of their values and practices, (ii) Maria herself self-identified as Malay and wanted to stay with her Aminah. So, despite her ancestry being Dutch, what clearly mattered in this case was the fact that she shared the values and practices of the Malay community. I want to note a crucial and subtle point: notice that Mills's intersubjectivist account is congenial with the problems facing Haslanger and pointed out by Appiah and Shelby, for he only advances a very minimal claim that race is contingent on intersubjectivist factors. He never claims that all races have the same intersubjectivist factors -- that it must be shared experiences of racism or culture or values for all races. This contextualist argument makes it compelling -- because we can accept that Chinese where values like filial piety are emblematic of being part of the Chinese race, while experiences of racism are emblematic of being Black in America. I think that it can even allow for different criterion for the same race in different national contexts: for instance, Chinese in America vs Chinese in China.

I think this also deals with the problem of heroic pasts quite well: just as the same race can have different intersubjective criteria in different nations, they can also have different intersubjective criteria at different points of time -- so while some races may take racism to be definitive now, then no longer taking racism to be essential to who they are once the structures of racism are dismantled does not mean that they are no longer of that race and are required to create a new race.

Now, I think that to fully capture the phenomenon of race, we need to complement this 'thick' criterion of race from a 'thin' conception of race which I take to be ethnicity. This can make sense of phenomena of race traitors and the question of "who are you really". Consider a highly anglicised Chinese individual, who is often questioned "who are you really" when they cannot speak Mandarin -- this question only has import just if there are in fact two levels of race -- one who you are minimally, and one who you are thickly, and the fact that your thick race can depart from your thin race. I think this allows us to reconcile the intuition that biological realism does not capture all that there is to the metaphysical import of race, but that there is always a recalcitrant intuition that ancestry does matter to some degree, even when defeated. This also makes sense of the Maria Hertough case: it is undeniable that our intuitions there are messy, and it explains why they are messy -- because we have conflated the thin conception of race (ethnicity as Dutch) and thick conception of race (race as Malay) as being on the same level when they are not.

Conclusion

In essence, the theory of race I take to satisfy both finding a criterion and explaining racial phenomena is the following: we have a thin conception of race that is our ethnicity, wholly determined by our ancestry, and we have a thick conception of race that has an intersubjectivist criterion which is local to a context, and explains much of the metaphysical import of race as a category. So, some races may depend on racism for its existence, but this is not true of all races, in all contexts. This, I think, is a far superior account than one which takes the existence of all races to depend on racism.

Highly original yet well blended with scholarship on the topic 82

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